HCP 1149 (cpc_1916-04-26_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-32): a Hungarian love letter from Árpád to Margitka Sziber

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

Status: deciphered in full (493 of 493 cipher signs, 30 distinct signs); independent review 1 verdict ACCEPT, no change to the decoded text. Report dated 2026-11-02.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1149 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1149), portal name cpc_1916-04-26_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-32, from Tobias Schrödel's collection of cryptographic postcards (private collection). When it was captured on 2026-11-02 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, tagged Postcard, T. Schrödel Collection, category Substitution, language Unknown, location Europe, sender Unknown, recipient Margitka Sziber, with no transcription or solution attached. The portal links a HistoCrypt article (https://ecp.ep.liu.se/index.php/histocrypt/article/view/166), which was not checked for this card.

It is a picture postcard. The picture side is a printed colour photograph of a young couple at a wooden fence with lilacs, scanned sideways, with no writing. The speckled patch at its top left is surface damage. The other side carries everything: the open address on the right and, on the left, a dense block of digits with marks. The digit block has a salutation, twelve rows of letter, three ruled boxes of verse and signature, and a verse of five rows written vertically to the right of the boxes.

The address is in plain writing: **Önsg. / Szépreményű Sziber Margitka kisasszonynak / Szomolya / u. p. Bogács** ("To Her Grace, the promising Miss Margitka Sziber, Szomolya, post office Bogács"). Two Hungarian stamps of 2 and 3 fillér are cancelled, but the postmark is inked over the stamps and its date and place cannot be read. The written date at the foot of box 3 is **Mezőkövesd, 1916. IV/26**, which agrees with the portal's file name. This is 26 April 1916, during the First World War. Mezőkövesd and Szomolya are close to each other in Borsod county in northern Hungary.

The card belongs to the family of Mezőkövesd cards to Margitka Sziber (HCP 1135 to 1179), written in Hungarian in 1915 and 1916. On most of them only key words are enciphered inside plain Hungarian. This card is unusual in the family: almost the whole message is enciphered, and only a few words in boxes 1 and 2, the place and date are open. The sender signs in cipher as Árpád. No identification of him beyond this name is offered here.

The key was **transferred from the family** and extended; it is not a blind recovery. The base was the key reconstructed on the finished cards HCP 1174, 1178 and 1179. No published reading of this card was used.



Picture side as scanned: a couple with lilacs, no writing (source/picture-large.jpg)



Address side: the digit cipher, the boxed verses, the vertical verse, and the open address (source/address-large.jpg)

Method

The transcription is **manual**. The solver read each row from enlarged crops (2.2x to 5x) of the un-converted original scan; the vertical verse was rotated 90 degrees first. No OCR was used and the portal supplied no transcription. The salutation decoded at once with the HCP 1174 key, sign for sign the same as on that card. The new values then came from words: `4.` = gy from hogy, 6 = j from jönni and majd, `6.` = ny from lányka, 2 = c from kacagni, and `:1` also for u from tudtunk, bukdostunk and sugára.

A sign is a digit plus a mark, and the mark is part of the sign: 1, `1.`, `1:`, `1,` and `1'` are five different letters. Word spaces on the card are only partial; the word division below comes from the decoding.

Several first readings were corrected on the enlargements before handover, always by rereading the pixels: the start of hűséges had been taken for an 8, three positions read as plain 4 were 4 with a fused comma, and the start of kedvesed had been misread. The solver had assumed the standard spelling kérdd, but the card has one d only, so the literal kérd stands.

The vertical verse runs bottom to top, its rows in order from left to right. This order comes from the orientation of the digits and from the rhyme.

Key

Monoalphabetic substitution of Hungarian letters and digraphs, register label MASC. Marks: `.` low dot or short dash, `:` two dots, `,` comma, `'` single high dot; `:1` means dots to the left of the 1.

Sign	Plain	Sign	Plain	Sign	Plain
`0`	o, ó	`2.`	é	`5,`	l
`0,`	ö, ő	`3`	d	`5.`	l (perhaps ly)
`1`	i, í	`3,`	r	`6`	j (new)
`1.`	a	`3.`	v	`6,`	n
`1:`	e	`4`	f	`6.`	ny (new)
`1'`	á	`4,`	g	`7`	k
`1,`	b	`4.`	gy (new)	`7,`	s
`:1`	ü, ű, u, ú (u new)	`5`	h	`7.`	sz
`2`	c (new)	`8`	m	`8,`	t
`2,`	cs	`9`	p	`9,`	z

"New" means added from this card to the values on HCP 1174, 1178 and 1179. The value 4 = f, tentative on HCP 1179, is confirmed here by félegyre, felmegyek, fogsz, fehér and fakaszt. The sign 2 occurs only once, in kacagni, so it rests on that word. The key has a structure that supports the new values independently of this card: the plain digits run in alphabetical order through consonants (2 c, 3 d, 4 f, 5 h, 6 j, 7 k, 8 m, 9 p, with b needing its own mark on 1), the comma series is cs r g l n s t z, and the dot series pairs digraphs with their base (`4,` g and `4.` gy, `6,` n and `6.` ny, `7,` s and `7.` sz).

Plaintext

Transcription from the card, one card row per line. `|` separates words, open`:` marks text that is not enciphered, and `;` separates open and cipher pieces in a row.

```
#HEAD
2. 3 1: 7, | 8 1. 3, 4, 1 8, 7 1' 8
#LETTER
2. 3, 8, 1: 7, 1 8, 5, 1: 7 | 5 0 4. | 7. 1: 3, 1: 6, 2, 2. 7, 1: 6, | 5 1. 9, 1.
2. 3, 8, :1 6, 7 | 4 2. 5, 1: 4. 3, 1: | 6, 1. 4. 0 6, | 7, 0, 8, 2. 8, | 3. 0 5, 8, | 8 1: 4,
6, 1. 4. | 1, 0 3, :1 5, 1' 7, | 3 0, 3, 4, 0, 8, 8, | 3. 1 5, 5, 1' 8 5, 0 8, 8, | 3 1: | 6, 1: 8
1: 7, 1: 8, | 7. 1: 3, 1: 6, 2, 1: | 5 0 4. | 1. | 5, 1' 8 9 1' 8, | 1: 5, 5 0 9, 8, 1. 8
8 2. 4, | 1 5. 1: 6, | 5 1. 7. 6, 1' 8, | 6, 1: 8 | 3. 1: 8, 8, 1: 8 | 8 1 6, 8,
```

```
8 0 7, 8, | 1. 6, 2. 5, 7 :1 5, | 7, 1: 5 0 4. | 7, 1: | 8, :1 3 8, :1 6, 7
3. 0 5, 6, 1. | 6 0, 6, 6, 1 | 1 4. | 1 7, | 2, 1. 7 | 1 4. | 1, :1 7 3 0 7,
8, :1 6, 7 )
1: 3, 3, 0, 5, | 8 0 7, 8, | 8, 0, 1, 1, 1: 8, | 6, 1: 8 | 1 3, 0 7
8 1. 6 3 | 5 1. | 4 1: 5, 8 1: 4. 1: 7 | 1: 5, 8 0 6, 3 0 8 | 5 0 4.
5 0 4. | 2. 3, 8, :1 6, 7 | 5, 1: | 5, 1: 4, 1. 5, 1' 1, 1, | 4 0 4, 7. | 3, 1. 6
8, 1. | 7 1. 2 1. 4, 6, 1 )
#BOX1
open: Nem kérdi senki, hogy a réten
open: Virág miért terem?
open: Ne ; 7 2. 3, 3 | 5, 1' 6. 7 1. ; open: hogy ; 7. 1 3. 1: 8 1, 1: 6,
open: Miért nyil a ; 7. 1: 3, 1: 5, 1: 8 ; open: ?
#BOX2
1. | 6, 1. 9 | 7, :1 4, 1' 3, 1. | 7, :1 8, | 1. | 3, 2. 8, 3, 1:
open: S ; 4 1. 7 1. 7. 8, ; open: ott ; 2. 5, 1: 8, 1: 8,
open: Reám sütött ; 7. 1: 8 1: 3 | 7, :1 4, 1' 3, 1.
1. 9, 0 8, 1. | 7. 1: 3, 1: 8, 5, 1: 7
#BOX3
7. 1' 8 8, 1. 5, 1. 6, 7. 0 3, | 0, 5, 1: 5, | 2, 0 7 0 5,
2. 7, | :1 3 3. 0, 9, 0, 5, | 5 :1 7, 2. 4, 1: 7,
7 1: 3 3. 1: 7, 1: 3 ( 1' 3, 9 1' 3 )
open: Mezőkövesd, 1916. IV/26
#VERTICAL (right of the boxes, written bottom to top; rows in order left to right)
2. 6, | 4 1: 5 2. 3, | 8 1. 3 0 6, 6, 1' 8
7. 2. 9 | 5, 1 5, 1 0 8 | 5, 1' 6. 0 8
8, 1: | 3. 1. 4. | 1. | 3. 1 5, 1' 4, 0 8
8, 1: | 3. 1. 4. | 1. | 1, 1' 5, 3. 1' 6. 0 8
:1 3 3. 0, 8 | 1, 0 5, 3 0 4, 7, 1' 4, 0 8 )
```

Reading in normal Hungarian (punctuation and spelling normalised). Square brackets mark the open words inside the boxes; all other words in the boxes are cipher. The first two lines of box 1 are wholly open.

Letter

Édes Margitkám!

Értesítlek, hogy szerencsésen haza értünk félegyre. Nagyon sötét volt, meg nagy borulás, dörgött, villámlott, de nem esett. Szerencse, hogy a lámpát elhoztam: még ilyen hasznát nem vettem, mint most, anélkül sehogy se tudtunk volna jönni, így is csak így bukdostunk.) Erről most többet nem irok, majd ha felmegyek elmondom, hogy hogy értünk le, legalább fogsz rajta kacagni.)

Box 1

[Nem kérdi senki, hogy a réten / Virág miért terem?] / [Ne] kérd, lányka, [hogy] szívemben / [Miért nyil a] szerelem[?]

Box 2

A nap sugára süt a rétre, / [S] fakaszt [ott] életet. / [Reám sütött] szemed sugára, / Azóta szeretlek.

Box 3

Számtalanszor ölel, csókol és üdvözöl hűséges kedvesed (Árpád) / [Mezőkövesd, 1916. IV/26]

Vertical verse

Én fehér madonnám, / szép liliom lányom, / te vagy a világom, / te vagy a bálványom, / üdvöm, boldogságom)

Translation

English. Sweet Margitka of mine! I let you know that we got home safely by half past twelve. It was very dark and heavily overcast, it thundered and lightened, but it did not rain. Lucky that I took the lamp along: it has never been of such use to me as now; without it we could not have come at all, and even so we only stumbled along.) I will not write more about this now; when I come up I will tell you how we got down, at least you will laugh at it.)

No one asks why on the meadow the flower grows. Do not ask, girl, why love blooms in my heart.

The sun's ray shines on the meadow and brings forth life there. The ray of your eyes shone on me; since then I love you.

Countless times your faithful sweetheart (Árpád) embraces, kisses and greets you. Mezőkövesd, 26 April 1916.

My white madonna, my lovely lily girl, you are my world, you are my idol, my salvation, my happiness.

Slovak. Moja sladká Margitka! Oznamujem ti, že sme šťastne dorazili domov o pol jednej. Bola veľká tma a silne zamračené, hrmelo a blýskalo sa, ale nepršalo. Šťastie, že som si vzal lampu: ešte nikdy mi tak neposlúžila ako teraz, bez nej by sme vôbec nemohli prísť, aj tak sme sa len tackali.) Viac o tom teraz nepíšem, keď prídem hore, porozprávam ti, ako sme sa dostali dolu, aspoň sa na tom zasmeješ.)

Nikto sa nepýta, prečo na lúke rastie kvet. Nepýtaj sa, dievča, prečo v mojom srdci kvitne láska.

Slnečný lúč svieti na lúku a kriesi tam život. Na mňa svietil lúč tvojich očí; odvtedy ťa ľúbim.

Nespočetnekrát ťa objíma, bozkáva a pozdravuje tvoj verný milý (Árpád). Mezőkövesd, 26. apríla 1916.

Moja biela madona, moje krásne ľaliové dievča, ty si môj svet, ty si moja modla, moja spása, moje šťastie.

Why the reading is believed correct

- One key decodes all 493 signs into continuous Hungarian with no gap. The key comes from reviewed sister cards and is extended by only a few values.
- The new signs recur in unrelated words: `4.` in hogy, nagy, vagy, így and felmegyek; 6 in jönni, majd and rajta; `6.` in lányka, lányom and bálványom.
- The story holds together: a walk or ride home in the dark under thunder, saved by a lamp.
- The open words fix the cipher. In box 1 the open word terem rhymes with the cipher word szerelem, and the open half of the verse sets up the answer that the cipher half gives. The vertical verse keeps its -om chain (lányom, világom, bálványom, boldogságom; madonnám nearly). Box 2 has no clean rhyme: életet / szeretlek is at most an imperfect assonance.
- The salutation and the signature match HCP 1174 sign for sign, and the addressee is the same woman.

Uncertainties

No word is unread. The points below are small.

- **Sense-assisted sign calls.** In these places the mark is fused or hard to separate and the word helps: the comma of `4,` in hűséges and világom; the `7,` in boldogságom; `0,` in sötét, üdvözöl and ölel, which looks like a 9 with a fused comma, as on HCP 1174; the first `8,` in dörgött and vettem; the tick at the foot of the 7 in the first értünk.
- **First sign of hűséges.** A closed S-shape close to an 8, with its overbar detached to the right. It is a barred 5, because mű- gives no word.
- **legalább.** The sign `1'` has a high dot and also a small separate dot at its foot, which strictly would be `1:` and give legalebb. It is taken as a speck or slip, on word sense.
- **Faint dots.** Some upper dots of `1:` are faint in szerencsésen, vettem and kedvesed. Both marks are present.
- `5.` **in ilyen.** This is the only `5.` on the card, and it stands where standard spelling has ly. The series pattern (g/gy, n/ny) predicts ly. On the other side, the finished cards HCP 1178 and 1179 use `5.` for plain l, and this writer also spells melnek on HCP 1160. One occurrence cannot settle it,

and the meaning is the same. The reproduction script prints the literal ilen.

- **Open words.** The S in box 2 is read as an open cursive capital; Reám has an a that can look like oi. Sense fixes both.
- **Writer's spellings.** eset for esett and kérd for kérdd. The key does not separate ü from u, or the long and short vowels, so these are supplied by sense in the normal text: tudtunk, bukdostunk, sugára and borulás are all written with the same sign as ü.
- **Marks without a letter value.** The ! after the salutation, a pair of short strokes below the end of elhoztam, dashes after mint, after raj at the row end and after the second sugára, the three) with no opening bracket, and a row of short dashes along the vertical verse. They are treated as punctuation or decoration; their exact meaning is not known.
- **Order.** The vertical verse's place in the whole message, after the signature, is an assumption.
- **félegyre** is taken as the clock time half past twelve (literally "by half of one").
- **Not checked.** The postmark cannot be read. No search was made for the verses in published poetry. The HistoCrypt article linked by the portal was not checked for this card.

Review summary

Reviewer: a separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent, round 1, verdict **ACCEPT**. The reviewer ran the reproduction command and recomputed the scan hashes. It wrote its own decoder with its own key table, which gave the same text, 493 signs, 30 distinct, nothing unmapped. It read every row itself from its own crops of the original scan, and agreed with the transcription apart from the one sign in the first finding below. It checked each flagged sign on the pixels, checked the picture side, and read the open address and date. It could not verify the postmark, nor whether the verses are published.

Its five findings were all minor and concerned reporting. No sign, key value or decoded word changed.

- **legalább.** The low dot on the 1' is now listed as a sense-assisted call.
- **hűséges.** Its first sign is now listed as a sense-assisted call.
- 5. **in ilyen.** The reviewer showed that the solution disagreed with itself on this sign. Both arguments, l and ly, are now stated and the value is left open.
- **Punctuation and picture side.** The list of marks is completed, and the picture side is stated to have no writing.
- **Box 2.** "Does not rhyme" became "no clean rhyme".

The transcription, key extension and decipherment were made by Claude Opus 5.5, with no earlier work on this number.

Sources

- HC Portal record 1149, General, Description and Attachments tabs, captured 2026-11-02: https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1149 (source/metadata.md).
- Picture side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3507/conversions/cpc_1916-04-26_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-32_pic-large.jpg (source/picture-large.jpg); original https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3507/cpc_1916-04-26_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-32_pic.jpg (work/hires/).
- Address side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3508/conversions/cpc_1916-04-26_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-32_adr-large.jpg (source/address-large.jpg); original https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3508/cpc_1916-04-26_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-32_adr.jpg (work/hires/).
- Family key: finished cards in this repository, ciphers/hcp-1174, ciphers/hcp-1178 and ciphers/hcp-1179.
- Reproduction: `python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1149/work/decode.py` from the repository root.